

BACK TO SQUARE ONE
Congress candidate Michael Lobo campaigning in Calangute

put the system in place in 24 hours," he declares.

The TMC, too, was an early mover on the caste front—even before AAP's Palekar gambit, it had made Kiran Kandolkar, a prominent Bhandari leader and an import from GFP, its state president. Kandolkar and wife Kavita are contesting from Aldona and Thivim, respectively.

The Bhandaris account for 30 per cent of Goa's 1.1 million voters and can clinch at least 17 seats. The community's 19 sub-castes constitute 63 per cent of the state's OBC population. Among the 13 people who have risen to be CM (for a total 24 times) since Goa's liberation from Portuguese rule in 1961, there has been only one Bhandari: Ravi Naik, who briefly got the chair twice in the early '90s. This is despite the fact that power in Goa is contingent upon how this largely agricultural community votes. In north Goa, their votes can often directly define outcomes. A Bhandari candidate with Catholic backing would be a sure winner. Explaining the arithmetic, a senior BJP leader cites Saligao in north Goa where Bhandaris are 45 per cent and Catholics 30 per cent. "All parties are fielding a Bhandari there, but they will need Catholic support to win," the leader says.

AAP seems to have understood the importance of the Bhandari-Catholic combination. Kejriwal has announced that the party will have a Catholic as deputy CM if it is voted to power. In 2017, AAP had projected former government official Elvis Gomes as its CM candidate to attract Catholic votes—Gomes lost, and AAP failed to open its account. Learning from its mistake, it has fielded mostly Hindu candidates this time, only taking care that most are from OBC denominations. "We are correcting the caste politics played by other parties," he said on January 19. Will this get Bhandaris to drift en masse toward AAP? Rajendra Desai, a political commentator, is sceptical. Goa does not vote on caste lines like UP, he says. "All parties have Bhandari leaders. The credentials of a candidate matter more than his caste in Goa," he says, but concedes

WITH PARTIES LIKE THE AAP AND TMC IN THE FRAY AS SERIOUS PLAYERS, THE CONTEST IN GOA IS WAY MORE FRAGMENTED, AND UNPREDICTABLE

AAP's gambit has made the Bhandari community realise its worth.

There are other forms of loyalties in play too. One of them comes into view as evening falls in congested Muslimwada in the St Inez area of Panaji. Carrying a mobile phone plugged to a power bank in his left hand, holy threads tied on his right, touching the feet of the elderly and shaking hands with the young, Utpal Parrikar presents a vision that's a blend of the past and future. The son of Manohar Parrikar now sports a beard, but the denim-clad 40-year-old still looks quite the scion—and is received that way by the public. At a house, an elderly woman calls him back—he has just turned after touching her feet. "You didn't tell me you are Parrikar," she said. "You don't need to come to us. You may count on our votes."

Utpal believes those who liked his father will stand behind him. But he may still struggle to create sufficient momentum around his headline-making rebellion against his father's party to take him to a famous victory. Panaji may be a constituency his father nurtured since 1994, but the politically well-travelled Atanasio 'Babush' Monserrate, the man Utpal was overlooked for, controls all the 24 corporation wards that fall within its limits. "If the BJP had fielded a clean candidate, I would have withdrawn," says Utpal. "But I could not be a mute and passive spectator to Panaji's steady but certain decline and eventful demise." The community arithmetic, though, is stacked against his independent candidacy. In Panaji, the 23 per cent Catholic and 20 per cent Saraswat voters are key to success. Utpal, a Saraswat without party backing, might find it a herculean task to shift the Catholic and OBC voters in his favour. Especially considering the strong resentment among OBCs on the caste front. The slogan 'Aani Ek Baman Aamka Naka (we don't want one more Brahmin)' has been getting traction. Just another signpost to the subterranean social shifts that have animated a long-static political field. ■